3Shamrocks.Studio

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Founder Brand Audit

40 checks, 90 minutes, one page of fixes. Audit your own brand the way I audit a startup's before a brand sprint.

8	40	90	3
areas	checks	minutes	fixes to start with

Dave Markovich · 3Shamrocks Studio

HOW TO USE IT

One sitting, one coffee, one honest score

You don't need a designer to run this. You need 90 minutes, your phone, and the willingness to score yourself a 0.

01 **Collect (15 min).** Open six touchpoints side by side: website, product (or app store page), pitch deck, LinkedIn company page, email signature, your latest social post.

02 **Score (45 min).** Go through the 40 checks. Score each **0** (no), **1** (partly) or **2** (yes). Write one line of evidence for anything under 2. Don't debate; first instinct, then move on.

03 **Test (15 min).** Run the 5-second test on page 8 with five people who don't know the company.

04 **Choose (15 min).** Put every 0 on the impact-effort grid (page 9). Pick three. Write them up in the "3 things" format on page 10, the same format I use for the one-page teardowns I send founders.

Scoring, as a rule of thumb

TOTAL (OF 80)	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS
64–80	Strong. Polish the lowest area and protect consistency as the team grows.
40–63	The brand works but leaks trust. The three fixes on page 10 will move it most.
0–39	People are working harder than they should to understand and believe you. A focused refresh pays back fast.

> Score what a stranger sees, not what you meant. You know what the product does, so you're the worst person to judge whether the first screen says it.

A First screen

What a stranger sees in the first five seconds on your site or app store page.

Area score ____ / 10

#	CHECK	SCORE
A1	**In 5 seconds, a stranger can say what you do and for whom.** Run the 5-second test on page 8 with 5 people.	0 1 2
A2	**The headline states the outcome in the customer's words, not a slogan.** Read it to a customer. Would they say it this way?	0 1 2
A3	**There is one primary action, visible without scrolling on a phone.** Open it on a phone at 390px wide.	0 1 2
A4	**The brand name appears next to the mark on the first screen.** Logo-only marks are forgotten when the tab closes.	0 1 2
A5	**The first screen shows the real product: a screen, photo or demo.** Abstract shapes don't prove anything exists.	0 1 2

EVIDENCE FOR ANYTHING UNDER 2

B Name and logo

The mark people will remember you by, everywhere it appears.

Area score ____ / 10

#	CHECK	SCORE
B1	**You have light and dark versions, each used on the right surface.** Check site, deck, social avatar, email signature.	0 1 2
B2	**The logo is readable at 24px: favicon, app icon, avatar.** Shrink it. Squint.	0 1 2
B3	**Nowhere is it boxed, stretched, recoloured or redrawn.** Check 5 touchpoints side by side.	0 1 2
B4	**The same file is used everywhere.** Different exports drift in colour and spacing.	0 1 2
B5	**Clear space around it is respected.** Rule of thumb: at least half the logo's height.	0 1 2

EVIDENCE FOR ANYTHING UNDER 2

Colour

Written down, measured, and the same everywhere.

Area score ____ / 10

#	CHECK	SCORE
C1	**The palette is written down as hex values, with one primary accent.** If it isn't written, every tool guesses.	0 1 2
C2	**Body text contrast is measured at 4.5:1 or more.** Use a WCAG 2.x contrast checker, not your eyes.	0 1 2
C3	**Success, warning and error each own a colour and also carry an icon or word.** Colour alone fails colour-blind users.	0 1 2
C4	**The accent is the same on site, product, deck and social.** Eyedropper it on each one.	0 1 2
C5	**If you offer dark mode, both modes were checked.** Contrast often breaks only in one mode.	0 1 2

EVIDENCE FOR ANYTHING UNDER 2

Type

Few families, a clear scale, readable sizes.

Area score ____ / 10

#	CHECK	SCORE
D1	**Two type families at most.** Count every font on the homepage.	0 1 2
D2	**Sizes follow a scale, not dozens of one-off sizes.** List the font sizes in use; aim for 6 to 8.	0 1 2
D3	**Body text is 16px or larger on web, with lines under about 75 characters.** Measure a paragraph.	0 1 2
D4	**Headings follow one case rule everywhere.** Sentence case or Title Case, never both.	0 1 2
D5	**Your fonts are licensed for how you use them (web, app, print).** Check the licence file or foundry page.	0 1 2

EVIDENCE FOR ANYTHING UNDER 2

Voice

How you sound in every sentence, including the boring ones.

Area score _____ / 10

#	CHECK	SCORE
E1	**One person throughout: "I" or "we", not both.** Search the site for both.	0 1 2
E2	**No buzzwords: leverage, synergy, seamless, game-changing, revolutionary.** Search for your own list.	0 1 2
E3	**Short sentences that pass a read-aloud test.** Read the homepage out loud. Where did you run out of breath?	0 1 2
E4	**Error and empty states sound like a person.** "No records found" vs "Nothing here yet. Let's fix that."	0 1 2
E5	**The same tone on site, product and emails.** Put one sentence from each side by side.	0 1 2

EVIDENCE FOR ANYTHING UNDER 2

Proof

Why anyone should believe you.

Area score _____ / 10

#	CHECK	SCORE
F1	**Every number has a basis: sample, period, comparison.** "2x retention (68% vs 34%)" beats "+68%".	0 1 2
F2	**At least one real, named example or customer story.** A logo wall without a story proves little.	0 1 2
F3	**Awards and press link to the source.** Readers check. Make it one click.	0 1 2
F4	**Product screens shown are real and current.** Old screens are the most common silent lie.	0 1 2
F5	**Nothing in beta or coming soon is called "launched" or "live".** Search for launched, live, available now.	0 1 2

EVIDENCE FOR ANYTHING UNDER 2

Consistency

Pick six touchpoints: site, product, deck, LinkedIn page, email signature, latest social post.

Area score ____ / 10

#	CHECK	SCORE
G1	**The name is spelled and capitalised the same everywhere.** Including the ™ and any special characters.	0 1 2
G2	**The one-line description is the same everywhere.** Copy all six into one list.	0 1 2
G3	**Colour and type look like one brand across all six.** Screenshot all six onto one page.	0 1 2
G4	**Screens and photos are up to date on all six.** Check the oldest one first.	0 1 2
G5	**Contact details are identical and work.** Send yourself a test email from the site.	0 1 2

EVIDENCE FOR ANYTHING UNDER 2

AI-readiness

Whether your AI tools can stay on brand without you watching.

Area score ____ / 10

#	CHECK	SCORE
H1	**Your brand rules live in one written file.** Not in someone's head or a 60-page PDF nobody opens.	0 1 2
H2	**The rules can be checked by looking: hex values, font names, banned words.** "Feels premium" can't be checked.	0 1 2
H3	**There is a list of claims you may make, worded exactly.** Anything not on it gets a [FACT?] marker.	0 1 2
H4	**The rules are installed in the AI tools your team uses.** Claude Project, custom instructions, skills, tokens.	0 1 2
H5	**Every AI-made asset gets a human check before it goes out.** A named person, every time.	0 1 2

EVIDENCE FOR ANYTHING UNDER 2

YOUR SCORE

Scorecard

AREA	NAME	SCORE / 10
A	First screen	
B	Name and logo	
C	Colour	
D	Type	
E	Voice	
F	Proof	
G	Consistency	
H	AI-readiness	
	Total	**/ 80**

Your lowest two areas

The single sentence a stranger should repeat after five seconds

A spreadsheet version of this scorecard (scorecard.csv) is in the download, with the evidence column ready to fill.

THE 5-SECOND TEST

Five strangers, five seconds, four questions

The cheapest brand research there is. It tells you whether the first screen does its one job.

1. Find five people who match your customer but don't know your company. Video call is fine.
2. Show your first screen (site hero or app store page) for exactly five seconds. Then hide it.
3. Ask the four questions below, in this order. Don't explain, don't defend, write down their exact words.

#	QUESTION	P1	P2	P3	P4	P5
1	What does this company do?					
2	Who is it for?					
3	What would you click first?					
4	Name the company (no peeking).					

Reading the result

- Three or more get question 1 roughly right: the headline works. Score A1 a 2.
- Answers are vague or about the visuals ("something with purple"): the headline is a slogan. Rewrite it in the customer's words.
- Nobody can name you: put the name next to the mark (check A4).

> Write their words down exactly. The phrases strangers use for what you do are often better headlines than the one you have.

CHOOSE

Impact vs effort

Write the code of every check you scored 0 (e.g. A4, C2) in the box where it belongs. Start top-left.

Impact on trust ↑

Do first	Plan
high impact · low effort	high impact · high effort
Batch on a quiet day	**Park**
low impact · low effort	low impact · high effort

Effort →

Usually high impact, low effort

- A headline in the customer's words (A2) · the name next to the mark (A4) · a source line under your numbers (F1)
- Current screens everywhere (F4, G4) · one written palette with measured contrast (C1, C2) · one buzzword sweep (E2)

YOUR ONE PAGE

3 things I'll fix first

The format I use in the one-page teardowns I send founders: what we see, why it matters, what I'd do. Short enough to share with your team today.

WHAT ALREADY WORKS (START HERE, IT'S TRUE AND IT MATTERS)

1

TITLE

WHAT WE SEE	WHY IT MATTERS	WHAT I'LL DO · BY WHEN

2

TITLE

WHAT WE SEE	WHY IT MATTERS	WHAT I'LL DO · BY WHEN

3

TITLE

WHAT WE SEE	WHY IT MATTERS	WHAT I'LL DO · BY WHEN

ABOUT

Made from real audits

I'm Dave Markovich, founder of 3Shamrocks Studio (since 2007). I've led brand and product design for over 20 years across HealthTech, SaaS and gaming, including the design and brand of the VIBRANT companion app. Before I propose any brand work, I audit what's there. These 40 checks are that audit, written so you can run it yourself.

If you want a second pair of eyes

The audit is the first day of my **AI-Ready Brand Sprint**, a short fixed-scope project: audit, identity refinement, colour, type and token system, a brand rulebook your AI tools can follow, and a set of on-brand launch assets. Details at **3shamrocks.com** or **dave@3shamrocks.com**.

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